ASHA PRASAD: PORTRAIT OF AN ARTIST

From the tangerine hues of an evening sun to the serene setting of a forest lake, delicate flowers in all their glory, and realistic human portraits – Asha Prasad's repertoire on canvas will appeal to any art connoisseur. "Painting for me is akin to meditation," says the self-taught artist who has been wielding the brush for as long as she can remember. Indeed, her works charm not just with their beautiful play of bright, subtle hues and earthy settings but also their lyrical, evocative, and sensuous lines…

Having treated art as a serious hobby, Asha was "forced to do a rethink," as she says, after she was encouraged by her hotelier husband, VK Prasad, to paint a portrait of her father-in-law soon after he passed away. "When we presented it to my mother-in-law, she was moved enough to say it looked very realistic and lifelike." Encouraged by the elderly lady's reaction, Asha became confident enough to immerse herself completely in the world of art.

Besides the boldness of color and deft strokes, Asha's work is a fine example of passion, commitment, depth, and maturity.

Other than her original works that take inspiration from nature and society, Asha also has to her credit stunning abstract art as well reproductions (artworks inspired by great artists such as Pierre-Auguste Renoir, Hans Johann Wagner, Ingrid Sehl, and Alfred (Alex) Gockel). Ask her about her favorite genre and she laughs, "It all depends on what my Muse wants me to work on at the time – be it a particular theme, a portrait or sketch, watercolour or a Tanjore, or even a crochet piece."

Having sold over 800 paintings to many hotels in India and Sri Lanka including those of the Taj Group, business houses, holiday resorts, and art collectors, Asha's works have also been part of exhibitions organized in Delhi, Chennai, and Surat.

She also enjoys teaching art to not just school children, kids in orphanages, and those with special needs but also to senior citizens. "Each person has an innate talent for art. I just let them discover it and enjoy playing with lines and colors," says Asha with a smile.